COMPANY DEEP-DIVE

COO at Deel Believes AI *Recruiting* Platforms Like *Micro1* Could Replace Traditional *BPOs*

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SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The interview covers the evaluation, selection, and implementation of AI recruiting platforms by a senior executive at a leading HR technology company, with a focus on product differentiation, customer and candidate experience, and long-term market opportunities.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- Chief Operating Officer at a high-growth, global HR technology company with extensive experience evaluating and implementing AI-driven recruiting and talent acquisition platforms.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- The expert is optimistic about the long-term potential and sustainability of AI recruiting platforms, emphasizing the importance of speed, customer experience, and adaptability.
- They believe that differentiation will ultimately come from depth of functionality and candidate experience, rather than just core features.
- **The expert sees significant opportunity** for these platforms to expand into broader markets, including potentially replacing traditional ***BPOs***.

TAKEAWAYS

- The company evaluated multiple AI ***recruiting*** platforms, including ***micro1***, Mercor, Paraform, Ribbon, and Braintrust, focusing on AI capabilities, integration, support, and trust.
- **Micro1 was selected due to its rapid feature development, strong customer service,** and willingness to incorporate feedback, which distinguished it from competitors.
- Core functionalities such as conversational AI and candidate comparison are considered table stakes; the real differentiators are speed of development and depth of features.
- **Candidate and customer experiences with micro1 have been very positive**, with candidates appreciating the interface and process, and the internal team valuing the support and culture.
- **The expert sees future opportunities for these platforms to generalize across more roles, automate more of the hiring process, and potentially disrupt the BPO market**.

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Expert Bio

Chief Operating Officer at Deel, a customer of Micro1. Expert can speak to their use case of Micro1 for sourcing technical talent, as the key decision maker who moved forward with their platform. Chief Operating Officer at Deel. Deel is a global payroll solution that helps businesses hire anyone, anywhere. Expert has the normal responsibilities of a COO which include looking after all operations, org design, purchasing, data design, and overseeing some strategic partnerships. The expert is very familiar with the office management space and is very comfortable talking about companies like Firstbase, Hofy, Grow Work, and RemoteTeam. The expert is able to speak to a variety of different areas like pros & cons, uses, etc. The expert has deep domain expertise across global employment, payments, HR tech, and compliance. They have implemented platforms such as Salesforce, HubSpot, Marketo, Deel, Pylon, Sardine, and Veriff, and are an active customer of tools including ZoomInfo, LinkedIn Sales Navigator, BVNK, Payoneer, Airwallex, and Wingspan Networks. They can speak in depth to evaluating and selecting contractor payroll solutions (e.g., Deel, Remote, Gig Wage) based on onboarding experience,

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misclassification risk, payment automation, and cost structure. They are well-versed in EOR business models, customer acquisition, global payroll regulations (notably in Germany), and the evolving U.S. market for EORs vs. PEOs. In payments and fintech, they have decision-making authority over vendors like DLocal, Airwallex, and Sardine, and are familiar with payment orchestration, FX/cross-border payments, and the trade-offs between third-party platforms and local entity setups. They are also experienced in HR tech evaluation across subcategories such as talent, DEI, and analytics, and have worked with platforms like Rippling, HiBob, Personio, and Reejig. In fraud and compliance, they have evaluated tools including Persona, Jumio, Onfido, Socure, and can speak to stablecoin-based infrastructure (e.g., Circle, Yellow Card) and broader trends in AML/KYC tooling.

Interview Transcript

Client 00:00:00

We've been doing some research into the AI recruiting and human data space. It sounds like **you've had a lot of great success experiences** both evaluating and looking to some of these platforms at Deel so far, and so we'd love to hear about some of your experiences. Does that all make sense, or have any questions for us?

If you don't mind, just starting with quick background. That way, it'd be great to hear about more specifically how you've looked into micro1 and other platforms in this space historically and maybe some of the original use cases, and then we can dive deeper from there.

Expert 00:00:37

For us, we spend a crazy amount of time on sourcing talent. The micro1 solution was immediately interesting to us. We're basically using it to source and then do a high-level screening and vetting of the talent, so it's a little bit deeper, I'd say, to an interview.

The way that I think about this as COO is when I'm needing to staff a certain team, I can publish roles to my job board, and seven days later I have a list of fully qualified, interviewed clients. Just accelerates the process so much. I don't know if you have background on Deel's business. Do you know what we're doing and where we're hiring?

Client 00:01:15

Definitely know Deel and some of the work that you guys have been doing. Can you first talk a little bit about just where you heard about micro1 and Mercor and some of the other players in this space in the first place, and then it'd be great to dive a little bit deeper into some of the use cases today.

Expert 00:01:32

Our talent acquisition team had the mandate to bring in new tools to help them automate and get more efficient. It's a classic story of talent acquisition at a start-up at Deel. Initially, all acquisition was done by the hiring managers and then HR joined and HR says, "We need to build that talent acquisition funnel, or we need to have sources," and before we know it, it's like 50+ people.

Not only that, but **the service level is quite bad**. Candidates are going days without answers, long lead time to book interviews, candidates are being ghosted. There's **a long list of normal operational problems**. We assigned a biz ops manager to assess the function and make some recommendations.

There are a ton of things. We set up different dashboards and alerts for people that didn't get back to candidates timely. We just started to build out for that SOP. Part of the exercise was to look what's available on the talent acquisition software market. There were a number of tools that we analyzed and built case study RFP for, and micro1 did particularly well.

Client 00:02:38

When you were first looking into platforms or tools in this space, were you looking into the Mercors of the world, the Paraforms? Can you talk a little bit about some of the optionalities and how micro1 compared and contrasted against some of those?

Expert 00:02:53

We also looked at in detail at Ribbon and Braintrust. We looked at three different buckets, maybe four different buckets. The first is the AI interviewer itself. What are its capabilities? Is it the primary focus of the business? Is there conversational AI? Is it customizable? Is there candidate comparison?

Second bucket was integration and compatibility. Does it integrate with our ATS? Would it eventually integrate with Deel if Deel builds out an ATS? Is there a mobile version? Not super important, but we did look at that. The final one was support and product development. Is there dedicated day-to-day support, priority feature development, candidate report quality? Most importantly is the trust. Do we believe that this pretty small business is going to be a trusted partner long-term?

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Client 00:03:43

Among the evaluation process, how did other platforms fare? Did you guys look into the Mercors, the Paraforms of the world? How did you compare and contrast that against micro1?

Expert 00:03:54

They're a long list. I think if I look at what really stood out, it's really the speed of feature development. It was incredibly quick in terms of building out things we needed, **that immediately won our trust and confidence**. Also, the customer service or customer experience part of things. How was it working with the team? Were the people good communicators? Did they care about us? Were they willing to take our feedback? **They really quickly shone out as the leader on these topics**.

Client 00:04:24

Sounds like execution was a big factor and product speed was a pretty big contribution in terms of choosing these guys over the other players in the market then, is that right?

Expert 00:04:34

Correct.

Client 00:04:35

From a product perspective, how do you think about that? Was that pretty different at the time? From a product parity perspective, were they pretty similar? Has micro1 separated themselves from a tech perspective? Do you see all the players so far as pretty similar from what they offer?

Expert 00:04:52

There are foundational similarities for sure. If I go down that list, is the conversational AI, it's binary, yes, no? Is there customizable voice, yes, no? Is there candidate comparison, yes, no? The point isn't is it a yes or is it a no for these early-stage companies, it's how are they going to evolve and deepen the functionalities. How good is the conversational AI going to get? How customer obsessive are they around the customizable voice capabilities?

Look, I would say in my opinion, the functionalities that these things need to offer, like the core functionalities, are really table stakes. You can't compete, you're not even going to go into RFP if you don't really have these things. What won the RFP is the speed of development and how deep we think these functions go.

Client 00:05:42

Maybe to take a step back first, within Deel, once you started implementing these types of solutions like micro1, what were some of the core use cases there? Longer term, do you see those use cases continuing to persist within Deel? How do you think about the longer term sustainability of platforms like micro1 and Mercor and others?

Expert 00:06:03

I think it's a very specialized and almost intimate topic. Talents and interviewing talents, it's the first touch point somebody gets with an organization in some cases. If they're [not] a customer, it cannot be the first touch point. **A huge amount of reputational risk**. **It's also an opportunity to make candidates, even failed candidates**, advocates of a company.

I don't think this is a space that even an aggressive $10+ billion company like Deel or like Revolut or like other companies that I've worked with would in-house. This is something that I think needs to be so, so specialized, and there needs to be an extreme amount of focus and attention to detail that it's really about candidate experience. Right now, the entry point on the wedge is really efficiency and service level. It's all going to end on candidate experience. Which software is going to give the candidate the best experience?

Client 00:06:59

From a candidate experience perspective then, what have you seen on that side so far? Has **it generally been pretty solid**? How would you rate that so far on micro1 with what they've built out on the AI recruiter side? Are you guys tapping into their human data product at all, or is it mostly on the AI recruiting and talent side of things so far?

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Expert 00:07:22

First of all, candidates love it. There's been a consistent theme of talking points around using it. That's good. We haven't had a need to use human data product yet. We're not training models or doing data labeling. There is a place where I can see it actually working, and I think **this is an interesting expansion opportunity for them**, is almost getting into BPO industry.

We hate working with BPOs. They're really inefficient. They make **us sign horrible contracts**. We don't like working with them. If I can go to a new BPO challenger where I can hire an SDR or customer support agents for X dollars per hour, then that's interesting.

Client 00:08:00

In terms of that then, is the opportunity to replace some of these BPOs longer term and try to take some of that market opportunity from those?

Expert 00:08:09

I don't see why not.

Client 00:08:10

When you first got in touch with micro1 and started working with them, how do you think about how that sales process worked, how fast you could onboard with them? Can you talk a little bit about just how the experience has been so far?

Expert 00:08:24

I think onboarding was relatively easy. The software and the application is pretty easy to use and easy to set up, where **it'll get more challenging is integrations with ATS**. For us, we were really given an amazing life of treatment, so it wasn't difficult. I'm just thinking as we scale, **it might be a little bit more difficult**. Experience has been great. I'm very happy.

Client 00:08:46

Do you mind expanding on that a little bit in terms of both the customer experience and then the end candidate experience? You touched on that a little bit already. Sounds like candidates overall have had a pretty good experience with that, but it'd be great to we have a little bit more detail.

Expert 00:09:01

I think that it's a nice product to use. Canvas, pick up on that. Is the interface beautiful and elegant and isn't spammy? The emails are all sequenced. That customer experience part is there. Second of all, the core functionality. The AI interviewer is great. After this, **our client experience has been good**. The customer success team that **they have on the Deel account is great**. We can speak with our rep whenever. She's always working late and early. I just think there's a good culture within this organization.

Client 00:09:32

From that team, who have you worked with so far the most? Has it been primarily from a customer success perspective? Can you just expand on that?

Expert 00:09:41

The girl we've worked with most is present, but someone else is pushing things along.

Client 00:09:46

How would you rate the team so far in terms of your experiences, their prowess, experience overall? It'd be really helpful to get a read on that.

Expert 00:09:55

High energy available. These guys are building a cool start-up. What else can I say?

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Client 00:10:00
That's definitely great to hear in terms of some of the managerial side of things. As you think about some of these platforms longer term, we've heard of, newer companies like Paraform and Brix. Mercor has been around for a while. Can you talk us through a little bit just how you think these guys try to differentiate or separate longer term?

I think I've hinted at different iterations of it, and something that **we're still struggling** with, trying to understand what that long-term moat is. From your perspective, can you talk a little bit through that and just how you think the market eventually converges here?

Expert 00:10:36
It's a difficult question to answer. I think **it's very difficult to build** an AI-based company that is sticky, a product that is sticky. HR space, payroll space renowned for being **sticky**. It's great. I think after this, the companies that do make it, they're going to be the fastest to adopt these new technologies and scale them, and the incumbents will eventually be displaced.

If I get really excited for a moment and I look at Deel, we just announced a $1 billion run rate. Who's going to be the first to introduce AI as it works today and eventually quantum computing? Is it going to be Deel, or is this going to be SAP or Workday? Probably going to be Deel. These AI-first companies, the way that I think about it is can they make it to unicorn status, can they become cash flow positive, and then after that they're off to the races. They could even become $100-billion companies with the right leadership and the right team.

Client 00:11:35
Just in **terms of the longer term market opportunity for micro1**, how do you think about the differentiation there versus something like a Mercor or Paraform? Happy to dive deeper into some of the perspectives that we've seen on some of the competitive players as well. It'd be really helpful to hear how sticky it is for you guys as you think about it longer term.

Expert 00:11:57
Why don't you give me a couple of your perspectives and then I can maybe reverberate, bounce off that a little bit.

Client 00:12:03
I think what we've seen is the Mercors of the world, they were the early starter in this space with the AI recruiting and human data side of things. From what we understand, **their AI recruiting product, the SaaS product, isn't very strong,** and so they haven't really been able to help a lot of enterprises that way. They really focused in on the human data component. It sounds like they've been able to sell to a lot of the big AI labs that way.

There's another company called Paraform, which is doing a similar recruiting marketplace, but more so the actual human in the loop, the recruiters in the loop. It's another approach that we've seen in the market. With micro1, it seems like they've placed a much bigger focus on that SaaS component, the AI recruiter, him or herself or itself. It sounds like that's been pretty effective. Trying to get a better understanding of what's the best approach or best strategy longer term out of all these different players since it's definitely a competitive space.

Expert 00:13:06
I think these players are going for the customer that they can sell the quickest and derive the most value to. I think there's a reason that micro1 has gone to the big AI companies. That's not because they can build better product for them or they're a better customer type. **It's just that the biggest opportunity comes there, and they're able to grow quickly with these customers**.

I look at Deel's journey, Deel v0, we sold to YC companies, and we processed payments for them. After doing that for like three months, we found that there was a completely different segment in industry, and at the time it was healthcare contractors. COVID came along, and we re-positioned ourselves to help pay workers during COVID.

I think micro1 is going after this segment because **that's where the most opportunity** is. They're making hay while the sun shines. I think that **those contracts will be very sticky** because it's never really done. However, there is a much wider opportunity here. For me, this is just getting started in a similar way that Deel is. I'm starting to sound like a very optimistic . It is just something that I think is quite interesting.

Client 00:14:15
It sounds like overall **the experience has been positive** so far. In terms of the longer term market opportunity, there's **a big opportunity** there, but then maybe longer term differentiation might be something for micro1 and all these players to think about.

Maybe my last question then is just in terms of where you would like to see development from the micro1 side of things, can **you talk a little**

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bit through from a product and company perspective where there's opportunities for them to continue developing on the roadmap? I think that would give us a better sense of just longer term sustainability for the company.

Expert 00:14:50

I think that right now it can't be used for every role under the sun. It performs better for different roles. I think first of all, generalizing. I think second of all, **the process of actually publishing a job description and publishing a role is a little clunky**. That can also be automated.

I go back to hiring process and before you even request a req and raise a JD, you should really have a scorecard. What do you want? How do you need this candidate to score for the role? That's often overlooked by many companies. Many companies just start interviewing. Each interviewer has their own interview techniques.

You look at big organizations like Amazon and Meta, they have a very structured way of assessing clients, and it's like actually that assessment part of it. Assessment for tech roles is a little bit easier because you can run these different tech scenarios on them and see how they react. How does that work for marketing? How does that work for operations? What are we actually testing the candidate on, and how do we know they're going to be a long-term success? That part is really almost overlooked at the moment.

Client 00:15:59

It's definitely a big opportunity for them going forward. How big was pricing in your decision when assessing micro1? How do you think that might change over time if there's less differentiation amongst these different platforms?

Expert 00:16:14

It wasn't a huge factor because the ROI is material. Whatever we paid, we're going to realize it returns pretty quickly. How will that change over time? I'm not sure on exactly how the pricing mechanics work. I think there are going to be more features that we'll want to buy from them. I think their pricing model is going to evolve over time as these more features are rolled out. The pricing wasn't really a big concern or big deal.

Client 00:16:39

Got it. This was a very informative and very helpful call. Have a great week!

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